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COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Former Head of Sales Americas at *Intercom* Believes *Outcome-Based Pricing* Boosts AI Agent Adoption Despite Challenges

DATE PUBLISHED	INTERVIEW DATE	EXPERT PERSPECTIVE	ANALYST PERSPECTIVE	PRIMARY COMPANY
08 Jun 2026	10 Mar 2026	Former	Business-Led	FIN

SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview covered strategies for upselling existing SaaS customers to AI agent products, the challenges and approaches to piloting and deploying these solutions, and the impact on customer spend and sales cycles. The discussion also compared the company's approach to those of key competitors in the AI support space.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Former Head of Sales Americas at a leading SaaS support platform provider, with direct experience in launching and scaling AI agent products, managing customer migrations from traditional SaaS to AI-based solutions, and overseeing sales cycles, pilots, and customer success initiatives.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- The expert believes that **outcome-based pricing for AI agent products is customer-friendly and encourages adoption, but acknowledges challenges with cost predictability and control** as usage increases.
- The expert feels that **the company struggled to effectively serve enterprise customers due to a lack** of sophisticated enterprise go-to-market strategies and support models, especially compared to competitors.

TAKEAWAYS

- The company introduced an AI agent product (Fin) that required customers to initially purchase both the platform and the AI agent, with pricing based on resolved conversations (outcome-based pricing).
- Customers typically started with small-scale or pilot deployments of the AI agent, often targeting low-risk use cases or specific customer segments, before expanding usage based on success.
- The company did not have a formal, paid proof-of-concept (POC) model like some competitors; instead, it offered short trials or small contracts, which required significant customer effort to set up and evaluate.
- Customer success managers and sales engineers played key roles in driving adoption and expansion of the AI agent, focusing on metrics such as involvement rate, resolution rate, and deflection rate.
- **Adoption of the AI agent often led to a significant increase in customer spend**, with Fin sometimes doubling the original contract value over time, though results varied widely by customer.

AlphaSense Assistant is AI Generated

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Expert Bio

Former Head of Sales Americas at Intercom Former Head of Sales Americas at Intercom, leaving in August 2025. This expert can speak directly to how a scaled SaaS GTM org evolves pricing, packaging, and sales motion as products shift toward AI/agent-led value, drawing on hands-on experience leading Enterprise and Mid-Market sales at both Intercom and ElevenLabs. They are well positioned to discuss seat cannibalization, expansion-led growth, enterprise pilots, and how to reframe value from “software licenses” to “AI capability” across MM and ENT segments. They can also go deep on operational GTM execution—including sales process redesign, global expansion,

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upsell/renewal mechanics, and aligning sales incentives with agent-driven outcomes. Head of Enterprise Sales and GTM at ElevenLabs. Former Head of Sales for the Americas at Intercom. The expert works to lead new and existing sales teams across MM and ENT for North America, Latin America, and Canada. The expert is also responsible for overseeing our Mid-Market and Enterprise Sales organization, advising our GTM strategy, operations, and sales processes. The expert is also working to manage a team of Enterprise Relationship Managers selling across North America, South America, and Canada. The expert is responsible for prospecting, upselling, expanding, outreach, renewing, and more. The expert has over 15 years of work experience in sales, management, and customer success. The expert is skilled in CRM, sales processes, and GTM strategy, and has a deep understanding of the mid-market and enterprise segments across various regions and industries. The expert works to advise and execute on our GTM strategy, operations, and sales processes, ensuring alignment and efficiency across the organization.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

Thank you for taking the time to speak with us today about SaaS companies. To start off, what approach has Intercom or ElevenLabs or whichever companies you can talk about taken to upsell existing customers from SaaS to agent pricing and packaging?

Expert 00:00:16

I'll talk about Intercom. Essentially Intercom obviously has a support platform. They have a very traditional support platform, ticketing, chat, full support triaging phone, SMS, WhatsApp. I was there when Fin was launched, which is their AI bot. We went through that whole business transformation, digital transformation from more traditional support into AI support. We took a lot of our existing customers on that journey as well as obviously bringing in net new customers, trying to get them to buy both the platform and Fin. At first, when you first launched Fin, you couldn't buy just Fin.

You had to buy Fin and the platform. We really had to help them understand how to augment their more traditional support model with AI. I think that there is a couple different schools of thought here around the pricing model itself. I think first of all, ***Intercom*** pioneered the ***outcome-based pricing*** model. They were the very first ones to ever do that. The way that Fin is priced is really customer friendly. It's very much based on a resolved conversation, which is when a customer does not come back within 24 hours or marks that a conversation was in fact resolved.

It's a really thoughtful way to price and it very much ensures that the purpose of it is to ensure that the customer actually sees value price Fin from the jump. That was how Fin has always been priced. I think there was a lot more openness even at the beginning when people were pretty hesitant around AI in general and **a lot of people really had a lot of fear**. I think there was a little bit more openness to test and try because it felt at the very least, if they were paying for AI and if they were involving AI in these conversations and if they were exposing AI to any part of their customer base and paying $0.99 for that resolution.

First of all, they could choose to expose it to a very small fraction of their customer base. Second of all, what they were paying for was the highest value interaction versus just paying what they do for Agentforce or they do for Decagon or whatnot, versus just paying for the agent to essentially be there and make noise. **It was received relatively well**. I do think that a lot of folks, and some folks still to this day choose to just involve Intercom or just to involve Fin and a smaller subset of conversations just based on the fact that because of the way outcome-based pricing is, there's not a lot of cost control that can be deployed.

Fin cost tends to be up and to the right where it's, just the more you use Fin, the more you use Fin. It just keeps getting used. People are more likely to talk to AI bots and talk to them more frequently than they are to humans and escalate to human support. Costs can get out of control pretty quickly and **it's pretty hard to predict or control cost**. Even if the cost is for something that is deemed more valuable, it's still more expensive and hard to predict than human cost.

Client 00:03:14

Got it. I definitely have a follow up question. It seems as though there's a couple different buckets. You all introduce Fin and then there are some people that are really excited about it, probably automatically opt in and are okay with that higher price with that outcome-based pricing, even if it grows on itself. There's a segment **that is a bit more hesitant** but wants to try it. What I'm hearing from what you said is that in order to get them onto Fin, you would basically try it for a subset of their solutions that they needed.

Expert 00:03:45

Yeah, a low involvement rate. Instead of involving it across a high percentage of their conversations, we've involved it for a subset of conversations or a small percentage of their audience. There's a ton of different ways you can slice and dice it. You can either have Fin be exposed to a certain percentage of your audience. Obviously a lot of times when you have Fin exposed to an audience, you have a CRM back end also integrated so you know exactly who's reaching out. You could say, "Okay, I only want Fin to talk to the lowest tier customers we have." Freemium customers for example.

If it's a paid customer or a VIP customer, I want them to always route to a human. That's one example. You could say I only want Fin to answer questions that are FAQ type questions like, "Hey, what are your hours or what's your return policy?" If there's anything that has to do

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with more logic-based or complex queries, I want that to go to a human. There's a lot of different ways you can slice or dice where Fin is involved in conversations.

A lot of times folks will deploy Fin in a small test type environment or a low-risk type environment to understand whether or not their customers are going to revolt or whether or not it's going to work or whether, or not they're going to see value, or what the deflection rate is going to be. There's very few if any customers that will buy Fin and then just deploy it across the enterprise. We've had a couple of, but those customers are insane. Most of the time there's going to be a more measured approach to deploying AI across a company.

Client 00:05:21

That makes a lot of sense. This pilot phase that you're talking about, was that something that they still paid you all for? Was it free? Like here's four weeks. How did you measure success of something like that?

Expert 00:05:36

There's a couple of different ways that this was done. We could do trials, which we did quite a few of and we would also do POCs, but really they weren't paid. Intercom does not have still to this day a model like Sierra. Sierra does a three month I believe it's still $100,000 to $200,000 POC where it's full blown side by side, they're building for you and then if you decide to sign the contract, that $100,000 to $200,000 gets lumped into your paid annual contract and then you are off to the races. Intercom does not have anything that. I think that's part of the reason why Intercom is not a true enterprise company. They just don't really have a lot of enterprise foundation.

The way Intercom does it is you can do a four-week trial where you can test and deploy and introduce Fin across a subset of your audience. **The problem with a trial** that most companies are not going to put a ton of effort behind a trial. The reality is with any AI bot, you do have to put effort into it, to making it work. Even if you're a mid-market customer, which is really Intercom sweet spot, it's still AI. Any AI is garbage in, garbage out. You have to make your content AI ready. You have to really prepare your teams, you have to prepare your customers.

Even if you're deploying it against an FAQ, low-hanging fruit type use case, you still have to make sure that everything's working and everything's set up the right way and configured correctly. It still has some upfront effort. To do that for a trial is a good amount of work for possibly not nothing. What a lot of customers did is they would do a two week trial and they would just tinker around and see if there was viability there and whether or not the product actually worked. If it did, they would purchase Fin. It'd be more of a land and expand motion. They would purchase a small amount of Fin.

Say do a $50,000 contract for a singular use case, for a singular treat as almost a POC or it's an annual contract, but it's for a small amount. They would deploy for that singular use case, that singular team or that singular customer grouping or whatever it might be. If that went well, as they tested and tinkered, then they would expand from there and amend the contract throughout the year. That's typically how it worked at Intercom because Intercom doesn't have a very sophisticated, thoughtful or designed POC type model a Sierra does.

Client 00:08:11

Got it. At Intercom this might not be the case, but were there a new type of hire that helped with these POCs that helped get people in line with change management and outcomes or even just if they buy the full contract, is there any FDE that or how was this service?

Expert 00:08:28

Intercom doesn't have an FDE model. They have sales engineers who are pretty good and solutions engineers. They also have CSMs and the customer success managers at Intercom. Intercom has relationship managers and customer success managers. The relationship managers are very much focused on the expansion of a contract. The CSMs are focused solely on Fin and Fin success. They're focused on getting you to your involvement rate, getting you to your resolution rate, getting you to your deflection rate.

Their entire focus is on Fin success. If you were a customer that had high volume on your website traffic, that you'd be defined as a prime Fin prospect essentially, or a prime Fin customer. If you were to buy Fin at a small volume, but we knew that you had a high propensity score, we would essentially give you a CSM and a sales engineer to ensure that whatever you bought us for went well, so that you had a high likelihood to expand.

Client 00:09:28

Got it. When you say whatever you bought us for went well, it seems the sales objectives, was that easy to track? Could you talk a little bit more about how you make that more black and white to then have people reach it versus.

Expert 00:09:43

I think it was relatively easy to track. The thing that I think is critically important, and we do this at ElevenLabs too, is before you kick off any work, whether that's for a POC or for a full contract, kickoff or even a trial, is to deeply understand how success is being measured. The

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reality is in this AI world, even though you might be working with two different banks, the reality is they are not measuring the same success metrics. It's critically important that you understand exactly what they're looking to see, either mid-trial or mid-POC or post trial in POC to say this was successful.

Some companies make it really obvious. It's like they're looking at the typical metrics of CSAT, NPS score, first response time. Any red alert signals from their customer base that they're unhappy with the AI, or any positive signals that they are happy with the AI, whatever it might be. There's pretty, pretty standard metrics and measurement that are being looked at by a lot of these companies that are pretty easy for them to track. Typically if we're doing a full blown POC, sometimes it's hard, we don't have access to their CSAT score, their NPS score on our side.

We do have to ask them to share that data with us. Usually if they're investing time and effort with us, they're pretty resistant to share that information with us. On the other side of the house, we have our own data that we track as well. We track the things the deflection rate. We can also obviously track first response time, involvement rate. I think Intercom pioneered their own measurement which, the CX score, which I don't know if anyone actually gives a shit about, but that does exist.

There's a bunch of different values and metrics that are shared and we also track overall customer sentiment. We'll do things after a conversation we'll run a quick survey and say, "Was this helpful?" We share that data with them. We always try to make sure before we kick off any trial that we understand deeply what they value and what they care about so that we can report back at the end and say, "Yes, this was successful." If mid trial it's not going well, that we can immediately pivot or make moves to make sure that it gets better.

Client 00:12:04

One quick question. It seems you also know a little bit about Sierra, so maybe Sierra, Intercom, and ElevenLabs. Are these pilots? Are you getting into them? These are sales cycles, RFPs. They're competitive. Is this you guys are initiating the pilot? What's the setup?

Expert 00:12:27

At Intercom, they were competitive pilots typically with one competitor. A lot of times that competitor was a Decagon. I feel that was our primary competitor at Intercom. It was Decagon and Agentforce and typically they were pretty competitive. It would usually be that these customers had gone and vetted a good amount of different vendors and then they decided that they were going to go to POC. To trial or to test with one or two vendors and then they're going to test.

Sometimes they'll test one at a time so they'll say, "Okay, we're really excited about Intercom. We're going to do a POC with you. If the POC goes well, we will buy. If the POC does not go well, we're going to then test the Sierra." Sometimes they'll do a test with both at the same time, see which one is better and then pick one. At ElevenLabs very similarly. A lot of times when we get to POC we are up against Sierra a lot of the time and it's a head-to-head POC and then they make a decision at the end with which one feels it met their needs the best.

Client 00:13:33

It seems it's a push or pull motion where they know that they want an agent tool and they're figuring out do I want a Fin or I want a Decagon, or a Sierra. It seems it's the same in ElevenLabs. Our situation is a little different. I'm curious if there are parallels to Intercom from here which is you have a SaaS product, you have all of these customers on this platform and then you're like, "Oh, now I have this agent product called Fin and here's why we think you should buy Fin." I'm wondering if there is that element too which is is this a different package in a way. You're offering more efficiency at a higher price. I don't know how if that was something which ever played out in sales cycles.

Expert 00:14:16

You mean because Intercom had a platform?

Client 00:14:19

No, I more mean the sales cycle is more Intercom went to the customer which were already on Intercom and said, "Hey, we have this new product, would you want to try this out?" It wasn't a competitive cycle because you don't have any awareness of having an agent before you introduced it to them.

Expert 00:14:37

I think for folks that have Intercom as a platform, selling Fin was relatively obvious. A lot of folks who already have Intercom had very high like hood to buy Fin. It was very, very rare that if somebody had Intercom as a platform, it happened. There are people that are Intercom customers that bought Decagon or bought Sierra and put it on top of Intercom, **that was always really disappointing**, but I think that we had a much higher like hood to win if they were on the Intercom platform. Especially because Fin integrates so beautifully with Intercom.

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Like how Agentforce has a beautiful integration with Salesforce, but I think it's a little bit different because **Agentforce's front end is so poor**, whereas Fin's front end is really great. I think the problem that Intercom faces. **Intercom actually does have a somewhat solid amount of upmarket customers**. I would not call them enterprise customers, but upmarket customers that are on the platform. **Intercom's AI motion for upmarket customers is not very good**. They don't really have a solid enterprise motion. Decagon came to these customers with a really well thought out enterprise go-to-market strategy.

That's where Intercom failed. You cannot go to a bank and say, "We can get you up and running on Fin in two weeks." A bank will say, "You clearly have no idea what you're talking about." We can't even start procurement in two weeks. Decagon came and said, "We'll sit down with you, we have an FDE team, we'll build with you, we'll sit down with you for six months. We'll build something custom." Intercom took the same exact go-to-market messaging they used for SB to enterprise out of the box. I think that that's what is lost.

Client 00:16:24

That's super helpful. It seems for someone Sierra or Decagon, do they also have a SaaS platform or is it the only agent-based?

Expert 00:16:34

They don't. They just have an agent interface. Although I have heard rumors that Decagon is building one, but I don't know.

Client 00:16:43

Got it. If you think about that, enterprise motion is more a head of the contract. We reverse it for you. If you like it, then that turns over into a full contract, essentially. That's the version of that.

At Sierra, is it mostly like, "Hey, there's a cost to that pilot, let's say $100,000." If people want to convert after the pilot, you just pull $100,000 into the fee or into the contract and then otherwise you part.

Expert 00:17:14

Yep, that's exactly right. ElevenLabs doesn't have a set amount for a POC, and we will do a lot of free builds. It's the means of by the end. We do a lot of paid POCs as well. We just don't have a set amount like Sierra does. We have a very similar partnership model. We will build custom for you. We work with a lot of pretty major brands across the enterprise.

Client 00:17:41

Got it. Are these, do you have a time limit on these POCs or these like one month, two months? How long?

Expert 00:17:50

We try to limit them to three months just because beyond that, it's like we're just in production at that point. I would say the majority of them are between one and a half to three months.

Client 00:18:01

Got it. The people who are running these POCs are these typical sales engineers or you've, specialized people who understand agents a little bit more about that.

Expert 00:18:11

It varies. The cool thing about ElevenLabs is we did not decide to go-to-market with agents Sierra and Decagon did. We are not limited to the support space in any way, but we have a bunch of agents in production that are being used in a multitude of ways. For example, we worked with Deutsche Telekom, which is T-Mobile and abroad. We run their Magenta agent, which is an agent for Deutsche Telekom where you can ask Magenta anything if you are a T-Mobile customer abroad. That's a massive use case.

We also power the entire Ukrainian government. We have an agent that any Ukrainian citizen can ask any question to about the Ukrainian government. Because of this, we work with a multitude of people across an enterprise on a pilot. It could be the CX or CS support leader. For Deutsche Telekom, we work with the CEO and his entire executive team because it's such a massive rollout that affects every Deutsche Telekom customer.

We work with the head of operations, we work with the head of marketing. We work with the head of sales. We work across a bunch of different teams because we are trying to do AI agents across the entire enterprise. Our buyers and the people who run the POC are totally different. Usually it's a combination of the economic buyer and somebody in the product and eng org that are co-running the POC to ensure that it's successful.

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Client 00:19:38

Got it. Who at ElevenLabs would be running?

Expert 00:19:42

It's going to be the account executive, whoever's deal it is and some folks from our forward-deployed engineering team. Whatever engineer is working to actually do the custom builds and then sales leadership. Myself or my counterpart in EMEA Europe and probably my boss or his counterpart in EMEA and then a lot of times Mati will also get involved as well depending on the size and scope of the deal.

Client 00:20:05

Got it. What's the approximate ratio? How many POCs can a forward-deployed engineer do at a time or is it one to one? You need at least one for every.

Expert 00:20:18

No. Each FDE is probably running five to six at a time.

Client 00:20:25

Got it. When you talk about Fin, you mentioned a little bit about the way you guys priced those by the outcomes. What was from an average group from the original Intercom pricing to maybe post Fin pricing? Was it an order of doubling the spend? Where were you from a percentage of increase there?

Expert 00:20:44

Do you mean as they grew over time?

Client 00:20:46

Yeah. Someone who's using Intercom then started using Intercom with Fin. Were they seeing a double in price? What was their traditional migration from a cost perspective?

Expert 00:21:01

That's so hard because it really depends. There were so many customers that ran the gamut. The really hard thing with that is if you're using Intercom as a platform that is your support platform so that's deployed across your entire support org. Every single person in support has Intercom so you're buying every seat. If you have 250 agents, that's 250 seats, and then there's multiple upsells and products you can buy within that. Your Intercom contract could be $250,000, and then you could buy Fin and only deploy it for a singular use case in the very beginning.

We talked about, you could start really small, and it could be $30,000 of Fin versus $250,000 for the platform. Over time, a lot of times, Fin would go up and to the right. I would say a lot of times, Fin would probably start at maybe 30% of your total contract volume, and then it would just continuously increase as long as the customer was a smart, thoughtful customer. A lot of times I would say Fin would end up getting to be about 50%-60% of their total contract spend, if not more, within the first year.

That is a little bit of an average because there were some folks that started small and stayed small with Fin. There were some folks that started with Fin and churned off Fin. There were some folks that started with Fin and then Fin drastically eclipsed their Intercom spend. It ran the gamut. There isn't a true number there. just anecdotally, from what I saw, I would say that would be the data that I saw.

Client 00:22:37

Basically double in a way?

Expert 00:22:39

Yeah.

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Client 00:22:40

Got it. Awesome. Thank you again for taking the time to speak with us today. This was very helpful. Enjoy the rest of your day.

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